commitments. A second foreign policy theme, pursued slightly differently under founding President Nelson Mandela (1994–1999) and his successors Thabo Mbeki (1999–2008), Kgalema Motlanthe (2008–2009), and Jacob Zuma (2009–present), has been to promote, in understated fashion, South Africa as a beacon and model of economic and political stability within Africa. This theme plays well within the continent—and also serves to market contemporary South Africa to the larger world.[266] Mbeki's version of South Africa as a regional leader leaned neoliberal, favoring increasing trade links and foreign investment for the country and region, while Zuma has been more populist, leftist, and less personally interested in the details of economic policy. South Africa's aversion to being seen to criticize any of its fellow African leaders on either their political or economic policies is even stronger than Brazil's similar reluctance to criticize neighboring states publicly.

There is today a clear competition between China and India for influence in South Africa, and sub-Saharan Africa more generally. South Africa, and more particularly the ruling African National Congress (ANC), has had a long and close association with India. Mohandas Gandhi spent twenty-one years at the turn of the twentieth century in South Africa, mostly in Durban defending the civil rights of the Indian community there, before returning to India to work with the INC. Following its independence, India steadily supported the ANC during the apartheid years.

China's relations with South Africa are more recent, and essentially economic, but have expanded enormously since the early twenty-first century. The first leaders' summit of the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation (FOCAC) was held in Beijing in 2006; the second in Johannesburg, South Africa's (and arguably Africa's) commercial capital, in December 2015. At the third India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS) in Delhi in October 2015, Prime Minister Modi pledged $10 billion in loans and investments. At the FOCAC summit just two months later, President Xi pledged $60 billion in new investments, an amount that surprised observers, as it was triple China's pledge of $20 billion at the previous ministerial meeting in 2012. Having its BRICS partners compete for its attention creates an attractive option for South Africa.[267]